

Performance Review and Career Progression Policy

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Review cycle

TechLance runs two formal review points per year.

Review	Period covered	Outcome
Mid-year (July)	January to June	Written feedback, no rating, no compensation change
Annual (January)	Full prior calendar year	Rating, compensation decision, promotion decision

New hires complete the 90 day initial review described in the New Hire Onboarding Guide before entering the standard cycle. A hire who starts after October 1 is not rated in the January cycle and receives their first rating the following year.

Ongoing feedback

Formal reviews should contain no surprises. Managers hold 1:1s at least every two weeks and are expected to raise performance concerns when they occur, not at review time.

A rating of Below Expectations may not be issued at an annual review unless the concern was raised with the employee in writing at least 60 days beforehand. If it was not, the manager must document the concern and the rating is deferred to a follow-up review.

Rating scale

Rating	Meaning
Exceptional	Consistently exceeded the scope and impact expected of the level
Exceeds Expectations	Regularly delivered beyond expectations
Meets Expectations	Delivered what the role requires, reliably. This is a good rating

Rating	Meaning
Developing	Progressing toward level expectations; typical for recent hires or recent promotions
Below Expectations	Did not meet role requirements; triggers a performance improvement plan

Meets Expectations is the expected outcome for most employees in any cycle. It is not a warning signal, and managers are instructed not to present it as one.

TechLance does not operate a forced distribution. Managers are not required to assign a quota of any rating.

Calibration

Before ratings are final, managers within a department review proposed ratings together to check consistency of standard. Calibration may change a proposed rating.

Where calibration changes a rating, the manager must tell the employee that the rating was adjusted in calibration and explain the reasoning. Presenting an adjusted rating as the manager's own assessment is not acceptable.

Self-assessment

Employees complete a self-assessment before each review. It covers what they delivered, what they learned, where they want to develop, and what support they need.

The self-assessment is an input to the review, not a scored component. An employee who rates themselves modestly is not penalized for it, and one who rates themselves generously does not gain from it.

Promotion

Promotion recognizes that an employee is already operating at the next level, not that they are ready to attempt it. The evidence expected is sustained performance at the next level for approximately two quarters.

Promotion decisions are made at the annual cycle. Off-cycle promotions are possible where a role change requires it and **require approval from the department lead and People Operations**; they are not within a single manager's authority.

Promotion is not automatic with tenure. Time in role is one factor among several.

Compensation

Compensation changes are decided at the annual cycle and take effect on March 1. Changes consider rating, position within the market range for the role and location, and internal consistency.

A strong rating does not guarantee an increase, and the absence of an increase is not a statement about performance. Managers must be able to explain the reasoning to the employee.

Compensation is confidential between the employee, their manager, and People Operations. Employees may discuss their own compensation with whomever they choose; TechLance does not restrict this.

Performance improvement plans

A Below Expectations rating triggers a performance improvement plan (PIP). A PIP must state: - The specific gap, with examples. - The measurable standard required. - The support and resources provided. - The review period, normally 60 to 90 days. - The consequence of not meeting the standard.

PIPs are drafted by the manager and **reviewed by People Operations before being issued**. A manager may not place an employee on a PIP unilaterally.

Successful completion closes the PIP with no ongoing record effect on future ratings.

Development planning

Every employee has a development plan reviewed at least twice yearly. It identifies the capability being developed, how it will be developed, and how progress will be measured. Funding options are described in the Tuition Reimbursement and Professional Development Policy.

Disagreement with a review

An employee who disagrees with a rating may add a written statement to the review record, which is retained alongside it. They may also raise the matter with People Operations, who will review the process followed. **People Operations reviews whether the process was fair; it does not re-decide the rating itself.**